

Most children have their own phone by age 11

By the time UK children turn 11, about **nine in ten** own their own mobile phone — and almost all of those phones are smartphones. That is the doorway to feeds designed to hold attention for hours.

This is not a scare story about every child. It is a reminder that personal phones — and therefore sticky apps — arrive early for most families.

CAREFUL CLAIM

Own-phone ownership is near-universal by late primary / early secondary in the UK (Ofcom).

DON'T CLAIM

Ownership equals clinical harm or addiction.

Cite: Ofcom, *Children and parents: media use and attitudes* (Children's Media Literacy Report) — by age 11, nine in ten own a mobile.

URL: <https://www.ofcom.org.uk/media-use-and-attitudes/media-habits-children/children-and-parents-media-use-and-attitudes-report-2025>

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In Ireland, smartphone ownership jumps at the end of primary

CyberSafeKids surveyed **over 9,000** Irish pupils in 2024–25. Among **8–12 year-olds**, **39%** owned a smartphone — rising to **66% at age 12**. Among **12–15 year-olds**, smartphone ownership was about **96%**.

Smartphone ownership among younger primaries fell versus the prior year (community delay campaigns may be one reason), but **tablets and consoles still open the same apps**. Delaying a phone helps only if other always-online devices get the same rules.

CAREFUL CLAIM

Irish school surveys show sharp rise in smartphone ownership by age 12; other smart devices remain common.

DON'T CLAIM

Official national census; that fewer phones automatically means safer online life.

Cite: CyberSafeKids, *A Life Behind The Screens / Trends & Usage 2024–25*.

URL: https://www.cybersafekids.ie/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/CSK_TU-24-25_Web.pdf

Full findings: https://www.cybersafekids.ie/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/CSK_2025_full-findings-and-appendix.pdf

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The product is attention — shopping is optional

The U.S. Surgeon General (2023) says we **do not yet have enough evidence** that social media is **sufficiently safe** for children and adolescents. Platforms use design features — notifications, autoplay, infinite scroll, likes, ranking algorithms — that **maximise time and engagement**. That attention is valuable to advertisers **even when a child never buys anything**.

Mind Reclaim's point: reclaim time and attention on purpose. You do not need a conspiracy theory to see the business model.

CAREFUL CLAIM

Official public-health advisory flags engagement-maximising design and unresolved safety for youth.

DON'T CLAIM

Mind control; social media alone caused a population mental-health epidemic.

Cite: U.S. Surgeon General's Advisory, *Social Media and Youth Mental Health* (2023).

URL: <https://www.hhs.gov/sites/default/files/sg-youth-mental-health-social-media-advisory.pdf>

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English schools are backed to keep phones off all day

In **February 2024**, England's Department for Education issued **non-statutory** guidance asking schools to **prohibit mobile phone use throughout the school day**, including break and lunch — with reasonable adjustments where needed. Approaches include lockers, hand-in on arrival, or secure storage.

Useful for Irish schools comparing policies; not automatically Irish law.

CAREFUL CLAIM

England DfE guidance backs full-day phone prohibition in schools (guidance, not primary legislation).

DON'T CLAIM

UK-wide statute; automatic mental-health or grade gains.

Cite: UK Government / DfE, "Government launches crackdown on mobile phones in schools" (19 Feb 2024) + accompanying guidance.

URL: <https://www.gov.uk/government/news/government-launches-crackdown-on-mobile-phones-in-schools>

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AI A1

Better with ChatGPT on practice — worse when it is taken away

Field experiment with nearly **1,000** high-school maths students: unrestricted GPT-4 help → about **48% higher** on practice than no-AI peers; on a later exam **without** AI, that group scored about **17% lower**. A “tutor” mode that gave **hints, not answers**, largely removed the harm.

If AI does the thinking, the exam still asks the student to think.

CAREFUL CLAIM

Answer-giving AI can inflate practice performance and reduce unaided learning; attempt-first / hint-only guardrails mitigate (peer-reviewed field experiment).

DON'T CLAIM

Ban all AI; “destroys brains”; Irish classrooms specifically tested.

Cite: Bastani et al. (Wharton/Penn), generative AI and high-school maths learning. Wharton summary (27 Aug 2024).

URL: <https://knowledge.wharton.upenn.edu/article/without-guardrails-generative-ai-can-harm-education/>

PDF: https://hamsabastani.github.io/education_llm.pdf

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AI A3

Official line: support human minds — don't outsource them

UNESCO's AI work for students and teachers says AI should **support human decision-making and intellectual development**, not undermine or replace it. That matches Mind Reclaim's second pillar — keep the practice that builds skill.

CAREFUL CLAIM

Leading education body frames AI as aid to human intellect, not substitute.

DON'T CLAIM

AI has no legitimate classroom use.

Cite: UNESCO AI competency frameworks for students and teachers.

URL: <https://www.unesco.org/en/articles/what-you-need-know-about-unescos-new-ai-competency-frameworks-students-and-teachers>

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Write this on the homework sheet

Suggested rule: “You may use AI to **explain after you have tried**. You may **not** paste a final answer you did not understand.”

Turns Bastani’s tutor-vs-answer-key finding into daily practice; matches try-alone-first without scare claims.

CAREFUL CLAIM

Attempt-first + no-paste-answer is a practical guardrail aligned with the experiment.

DON'T CLAIM

Magical fix; need to read every chat.

Cite: Action derived from Bastani et al. (A1).

URL: <https://knowledge.wharton.upenn.edu/article/without-guardrails-generative-ai-can-harm-education/>

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